

current chief M. Natarajan. "The Arjun can handle all present and future threats," says the DRDO. This war of words between the army and DRDO could well be among the penultimate chapters in the long sad story of a saga that began with the army placing General Staff Qualitative Requirement (GSQR) for an indigenous tank in May 1974. The project was to cost Rs 15.50 crore and to be completed in a decade. The first production model of 'Chetak', as it was then called, which rolled out in 1984, was wisely renamed the Arjun. Plagued by technical glitches—its European electronics did not work in the searing circuit-melting 50 degree heat of the Thar desert—the final production series tank was not delivered until 1995

ARJUN NUMBERS	
COST PER TANK:	Rs 17 Cr
TANKS PRODUCED:	90
PRESENT ORDER SIZE:	124
TOTAL INVESTMENT BY DRDO:	Rs 300 Cr
NUMBER OF TANKS NEEDED TO BREAK EVEN:	500
NUMBER OF NEW ARJUNS MOD PLANS TO ORDER:	124

the more modern T-80s. There was no sign of the Arjun.

Delays in productionising the design ensured the order for 124 tanks was not placed to the OFB until 2002 and production did not begin until 2004 or nearly three decades after the project had been conceived. "The Arjun was not available when we needed it," says a senior army official.

The army was hence forced to import 310, T-90 tanks from Russia in 2001 to sharpen the tip of its armoured spear. The door had begun to close on the Arjun which was still jumping through the hoops of the army's trials. Even as the tank struggled to meet GSQRs, the army would add new demands citing delays and changes in the global scenario. "The army's GSQR was always a moving goal post," says a DRDO-armoured vehicle scientist. "You cannot have a tank with the best-of-the-world-systems."

Yet the Arjun managed to do this and more. Some of the state-of-the-art technologies incorporated in the tank include a modern fire control system with Fire Control Computer and multiple rocket system—which gives it the ability to blast targets placed over a km away while on the move, a gas-based suspension, a unique 'Kanchan' composite armour capable of withstanding direct hits from T-72 and T-90 tanks, lethally accurate fin-stabilised armour piercing discarding sabot ammunition and kinetic



BEHEMOTH: Arjun tanks at the Heavy Vehicles Factory in Chennai

...AND NO TAKERS

or a decade after the original deadline. Perhaps the DRDO strategically overreached itself on this project as it had on several others. It agreed to deliver everything on the tank when it should have gone in for a no-frills Mark 1. This was clearly not the case when the tank was due for induction into service by an already extended deadline of 1995 and an exasperated army did not get its tanks.

The army, which has around 3,500 tanks in 61 armoured regiments—each

with 45 tanks, mostly T-72s imported and licence-produced from Russia in the early '80s serving as first line MBTs—has this complaint. The Arjun did not come on time. Not even when the acquisition of 300 Ukrainian missile-firing T-80s by Pakistan in 1997 dangerously tilted the balance of armoured power on the subcontinent. (Tanks can only be used on the deserts and plains of India's western borders). Even during Operation Parakram, the near-war with Pakistan in December 2001, the army found its T-72s, obsolete T-55s and Vijayantas staring down the gunsights of

energy penetrators which can shatter enemy tanks. Nuclear-Biological-Chemical protection not to speak of the ability of the 60-tonne monster to spin full circle on a coin in 12 seconds.

During the desert trials which concluded last week the tanks also rectified two problems raised by Army Chief General Deepak Kapoor during a visit to the CVRDE in May—premature failure of engine transmission and gun accuracy.

However, it finds that the army has shifted the goal posts again. This time, to over the horizon. "Arjun is a contemporary tank and may be used in the